by now, the astronomical costs of this never-ending war and also continue to receive body bags of dead US soldiers killed in combats.

India realises that once the US pulls out of Afghanistan, Pakistan is going to invite China to send its troops into Afghanistan, as they themselves cannot bear the costs of using Afghanistan for their tactical and strategic moves against India. And China needs to regulate a post-US Afghanistan because it not only needs to deny the use of that country as a launching pad for Uighur freedom fighters into neighbouring Chinese-occupied Xinjiang, but also to further pressurise and bleed India in Kashmir.

For India, an imperative was to pre-emptively act in moving its own dominoes on this dynamic chessboard and not react to the changes that would be put into place within the next few months when the US withdrawal from Afghanistan would be over. An indication was provided by the sudden spike in cross-border shelling across the LoC that intensified in Jammu & Kashmir, and the return of the *jihadi* fighters back to the LoC, as soon as Pakistani Prime Minister Imran Khan and his generals returned home from the US. Attacks by Pakistan's Border Action Team (BAT) on India's forward posts were intercepted by the Indian Army, and also successfully fought off BAT incursions at locations in the Keran, Gurez, Machil and Tangdhar sectors along the LOC by even killing some Pakistan-based intruders.

On Friday, 2 August 2019, the Government of India asked all pilgrims undertaking the pilgrimage to the Amarnath shrine and all tourists and outsiders in the Kashmir Valley to immediately leave the state as soon as possible citing a security threat based on intelligence inputs. And in an unusually rare move, the Jammu & Kashmir Government also officially cancelled the pilgrimage for this year. Thereafter, Section 144 of the Indian Penal Code was put in place in the entire state banning an assembly of more than four persons. Late at night, on Sunday, 4 August 2019, all important politicians in the state were put under house arrest.

The final coup de grâce to the debate on the special status of the state of Jammu & Kashmir that had been continuing since 1953, when Jana Sangh leader, Shyama Prasad Mookerjee, first raised it, was delivered in the